▼ VIEWPOINT

SEVEN PILLARS FOR A TERROR STRIKE FORCE

India's new counter-terrorism policy, encapsulated in the seven-lettered acronym PRAHAAR, formally enunciates practices already being implemented



BY DR ADIL RASHEED

It is remarkable that much of the Union home ministry's recently unveiled National Counter-Terrorism Policy and Strategy called 'PRAHAAR' uses the present perfect signifier "has been" instead of future indefinite verbs 'will be' or 'shall be'. Thus the first formal enunciation of its counter-terrorism policy indicates that much of it has already been implemented.

A remarkable feature of this policy brief is crisply imbued in its 7-letter acronym PRAHAAR ('strike' in English), with each letter pointing to a specific facet of the counter-terrorism strategy. Thus, the first letter 'P' stands for "Prevention of terrorist attacks", while the following 'R' is associated with "Response...swift and proportionate". The next letter 'A' stands for "aggregating internal capacities", followed by 'H' that connotes "Human Rights and Rule of Law". The subsequent pair of 'As' refer to "Attenuating the conditions enabling terrorism" and "Aligning and shaping international efforts to counter terrorism". The final 'R' is dedicated to "Recovery and resilience through a whole-of-society approach". Thereafter, the paper provides separate sections for each the themes.

In its threat assessment, the document mentions the menace of "jihadi terror outfits as well as their frontal organisations". It points out the threat posed by cross-border terror groups and transnational terror organisations like Al-Qaeda and ISIS. However, there is no explicit mention of the threat posed by Khalistan terror outfits, LWE groups or northeastern insurgent forces.

One of the less celebrated successes of India's counter-terrorism operations has been the effort of security agencies to isolate, localise and de-politicise counter-radicalisation campaigns so that no religious or ethnic community feels unduly targeted. In fact, such campaigns have involved community elders, religious leaders and members of the family in reclaiming a prospective deviant away from the path of radicalisation.



Illustration by RAJ VERMA

CURIOUSLY, THE PAPER HAS ONLY A PASSING REFERENCE TO DE-RADICALISATION PROGRAMMES, ALTHOUGH THEY ARE THE TOPIC OF HEATED POLITICAL DEBATE WORLDWIDE

Curiously, the policy paper makes only a passing reference to de-radicalisation programmes, a topic that has been a subject of heated political debate worldwide. While Western states have mostly closed such programmes on account of their relatively high recidivism rate, they have reportedly shown better results in Southeast Asian countries. Given the mixed results, Indian central and state governments have been largely reluctant to introduce Western-style individual-centric deradicalisation programmes.

It is also heartening to note that Indian counter-terrorism policy is well in the know about the abuse of social media platforms and instant messaging applications for "communication, funding and guiding terror attacks" and has on its radar the threats posed by "encryption, dark web, crypto, wallets etc". The paper makes special mention of Pakistan-based cross-border threats posed by drones and expresses concerns over CBRNED (chemical, biological, radiological, nuclear, explosive, digital) threats. Highlighting these concerns in a policy paper is often indicative of steps taken to counter the threats without making them public.

The policy document stresses that "India adheres to the 'Rule of Law', where laws are just, applied evenly and protect fundamental rights". After naming an exclusive list of counter-terrorism legislation, it points out that "multiple levels of legal redressal are available to any accused through an elaborate infrastructure of the justice system from the districts, through states, right up to the higher judiciary at the central level. The due process of law gives wide scope to the Supreme Court for protection of the rights of citizens".

Having established above that India's counter-terrorism policy predates its present official disclosure, we may well question the need to publish the document now. One can only speculate that as part of India's ongoing Operation Sindoor, the government now seeks to launch a major public relations campaign to clear any misapprehensions regarding its commitment towards combating terrorism. In any case, India's first counter-terrorism policy document is a welcome step in the right direction and, like the title of its concluding section, it duly charts a visionary 'Way Forward'. ■

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